Hiring Manager View: CV & LinkedIn

Role A — Hiring Manager's view (HR / Hiring Manager)

UrbanStyle is a fast-growing retail and e-commerce company, so the hiring manager should look for candidates who can do more than use analytical tools. A strong candidate should be able to work with different types of business data, communicate findings clearly and turn analysis into useful decisions.

What I would look at first

When screening a CV, I would first try to answer five questions:

- Is it immediately clear that this person is relevant for a Data Analyst role?
- Do they have evidence of using SQL and Python on real analytical problems?
- Can I see business outcomes, not just a list of responsibilities?
- Have they worked with data that is relevant to a retail, e-commerce or customer-focused business?
- Is there a portfolio or GitHub where I can verify the work?

Because UrbanStyle is a relatively small and fast-growing company, I would also look for signs that the candidate is **versatile and independent** rather than specialised in only one narrow analytical task.

What makes a strong CV for UrbanStyle

A strong CV should connect technical skills to business problems. For example, instead of:

"Used Python and SQL for data analysis."

A stronger description would be:

"Analysed customer and sales data using SQL and Python, identified a high-value customer segment and translated the findings into retention recommendations."

Useful evidence would include:

- sales or revenue analysis
- customer segmentation or retention analysis
- KPI and performance reporting
- e-commerce or retail analytics
- dashboard development
- automation of repetitive reporting or data-processing tasks
- recommendations that led to a measurable business outcome

Results should be quantified where possible: revenue, percentage change, customers affected, records analysed or hours of manual work saved.

LinkedIn — what is worth featuring

The Featured section should show the candidate's **strongest evidence**, not simply the largest number of projects. For UrbanStyle, particularly relevant projects would be:

1. Sales or retail performance analysis

Shows that the candidate can understand revenue, trends, locations, products and business KPIs.

2. Customer segmentation or retention project

Shows the ability to move from customer-level data to a business recommendation.

3. Automated analytics pipeline

Shows Python skills, independence and the ability to make analytics repeatable rather than relying on manual work.

4. Business dashboard

Shows the ability to communicate data clearly to managers who may not be technical.

A strong featured project should make it easy to understand:

Business question → Analysis → Result → Recommendation

Green flags

1. **Business impact is visible** — The candidate describes what changed because of the analysis — for example increased revenue opportunity, cost reduction, better targeting or time saved.
2. **Technical skills are supported by evidence** — SQL, Python, visualisation and other tools appear inside real projects rather than only in a Skills section.
3. **The candidate demonstrates end-to-end ownership** — They can take a business question, work with the data, analyse it, communicate the result and make a recommendation. This is particularly valuable in a small, fast-growing company where an analyst may need to work across several areas.

Red flags

1. **Tool-heavy but outcome-light CV** — The candidate lists SQL, Python, Power BI, Tableau and many other technologies, but it is difficult to understand what they actually achieved with them.
2. **Projects stop at the analysis** — The candidate shows queries, charts or dashboards but does not explain the business question, finding or recommendation. For UrbanStyle, analysis should help someone make a decision.

Additional consideration for UrbanStyle

Because the company works across several locations and is also hiring remotely, the CV and LinkedIn profile should contain some evidence of clear communication, collaboration and independent work. For remote candidates especially, it is useful to see examples of:

- documented work
- collaboration through shared tools or GitHub
- presenting findings to stakeholders
- working independently with a clearly defined outcome

Main hiring-manager principle

For UrbanStyle, I would prioritise **evidence over claims**. The strongest candidate is not the person who lists the most tools. It is the person whose CV and LinkedIn make it easy to see:

I can work with the data → I can find something useful → I can explain why it matters → I can help the business decide what to do next.

ROLE B - Technical Interviewer's View

When I review a data analyst candidate's technical work, I'm not looking for perfect code, rather evidence that someone can think clearly, work with real data, and leave a trail other people can follow. A junior candidate won't be an expert in everything, and that's fine. What matters is whether the fundamentals are solid and whether I can trust what I'm looking at.

Code quality: readability, comments, structure

I want code that reads like it was written for a colleague, not just for the computer to execute. That means meaningful and clear variable names (`customer_segment`), functions broken into logical steps rather than one giant block, and comments that explain why a decision was made, not just restating what the line does. For example, if a candidate filtered out rows where `total_price <= 0`, a one-line comment noting that this removes data-entry errors tells me they understood the data, not just copied a pattern.

Tool familiarity: SQL, Python, Power BI / Plotly, Git

SQL is non-negotiable, I expect to see JOINs, GROUP BY, and ideally CTEs used naturally, not just basic SELECT statements. For Python, I look for pandas used correctly (proper handling of NULLs and duplicates etc.). For visualisation, I check whether charts are chosen to fit the question being asked, not just whatever was easiest to generate. And Git usage tells me a lot on its own: a history of small, descriptive commits over time says more about someone's working habits than a single "final version" commit ever could.

Documentation: READMEs, commit messages

This is where a lot of otherwise strong candidates fall short. A README should tell me, in plain language, what business question the project answers, which tools were used, and what the result was — without me having to read every line of code to figure it out. Commit messages matter too: "fix bug" tells me nothing; "fix pagination bug that was truncating sales data to 1,000 rows" tells me the candidate understood the problem they solved.

Green flags (strong candidate):

- Commit history shows iteration and real debugging, evidence of catching and fixing a genuine mistake (e.g. a data pagination issue, an incorrect join), not just a clean final version with no visible process.
- README files explain the business context and result in plain language, not just a list of technical steps.
- Code includes basic error handling (try/except around API calls or file operations) even in a learning project, a sign the candidate is already thinking about production-readiness.

Red flags (warning signs):

- No comments or documentation anywhere, code that only makes sense to the person who wrote it, which becomes a liability the moment they leave or hand off the project.
- Copy-pasted code patterns that don't match the rest of the project's logic, often a sign of not actually understanding what was used, just assembling fragments.

Three key recommendations for management

- **Recommendation 1:** Standardise the technical interview around a short, real task (e.g. "write a query that finds the top 5 customers by revenue") rather than abstract trivia questions — it reveals actual working ability in minutes.
- **Recommendation 2:** Weight the GitHub portfolio and README quality as heavily as the live interview — a well-documented project is a stronger signal of production-readiness than interview performance alone.
- **Recommendation 3:** For the two remote hires (Finland, Germany), add a documentation-specific check — ask candidates to walk through a README as if explaining it to someone who can't ask follow-up questions in person, since async communication matters more for remote team members.

People Manager

Focus: Communication, problem-solving, teamwork and cultural fit

Project: UrbanStyle.ltd — Data Analyst Hiring Guide | **Role:** C — People Manager

1. What I Would Look for in a Candidate

As a People Manager, I believe technical skills are important, but how someone works with others matters just as much. I would look for the following qualities:

Communication: A good analyst should be able to explain their findings in a way that everyone understands, not just people with technical knowledge. They should also listen carefully and make sure others understand what they are trying to communicate.

Problem-solving: I would value someone who is curious and willing to investigate when something doesn't look right. Instead of ignoring unexpected results, they should check their work, understand what went wrong and look for a solution. For example, if UrbanStyle's sales report showed unexpected numbers, I would expect an analyst to investigate the data, communicate the problem to the team and explain what they discovered before recommending a solution.

Teamwork: A good teammate communicates their progress, shares knowledge and offers help when needed. Being sociable and approachable can make it easier for others to ask questions and work together. However, someone doesn't need to be outgoing to be a good team player.

Cultural fit: I would look for someone who is open-minded, respects different opinions and is willing to learn. Nobody knows everything, and being able to recognise mistakes and improve is a strength. Candidates should also feel comfortable disagreeing respectfully when they have a good reason.

2. Three Green Flags

1. **Open-mindedness:** The candidate can describe a time they received feedback, reflected on it and improved their work.
2. **Clear communication:** They listen to questions and explain their ideas in a way that makes sense to both technical and non-technical people.
3. **Supportive teamwork:** They share information, communicate challenges and are willing to help teammates succeed.

3. Two Red Flags

1. **Difficulty communicating important concerns:** The candidate repeatedly avoids explaining problems or raising concerns, even when given an opportunity to clarify. This could affect the team's ability to work together.
2. **Unwillingness to learn:** The candidate dismisses feedback or refuses to reconsider their approach, even when evidence suggests something should change.

4. Practical Interview Question

“Can you tell me about a time you disagreed with feedback from a manager or teammate? How did you handle it?”

I would listen to how the candidate explains the situation, whether they considered the other person's opinion and what they learned. I wouldn't automatically see disagreement with a manager as a problem. Sometimes the employee may have a valid point. What matters is how they communicate and whether they are willing to consider evidence.

5. Recommendation to Liis

I would recommend that UrbanStyle asks candidates for real examples of how they communicate, solve problems and work with others. Rather than choosing someone simply because they sound confident or outgoing, the hiring team should focus on how candidates actually behave and respond to challenges. A good analyst doesn't have to know everything from the beginning, but they should be willing to learn, ask questions and help the team move forward.

Team Lead's Perspective

Evaluating Data Analyst Candidates

As a Data Team Lead at UrbanStyle, technical proficiency in SQL, Python, or BI tools is only the baseline. What truly separates a solid candidate from an exceptional hire is how effectively they work within our cross-functional environment. When evaluating Data Analyst (DA) candidates, I look at four core behavioral pillars: Independence, Communication, Collaboration, and Growth Potential.

1. Core Evaluation Pillars & Criteria

Independence: Autonomous Problem Solving

A strong candidate doesn't just wait for explicit instructions—they own the problem end-to-end.

What I look for: The ability to unblock oneself. When facing messy data or ambiguous business questions, can the candidate form hypotheses, investigate data schemas independently, and validate their findings before escalating?

UrbanStyle Context: If our e-commerce checkout funnel data drops unexpectedly, an independent analyst doesn't just report “data is missing.” They check pipeline logs, cross-reference transaction IDs across payment gateways, and bring a diagnosed issue along with 2–3 possible root causes.

Communication: Translating Complexity into Business Clarity

Data is useless if stakeholders cannot understand or act on it.

What I look for: Clear, jargon-free explanations tailored to the audience. I evaluate whether candidates lead with the “so what?” (business impact and recommendations) rather than getting bogged down in technical methodology.

UrbanStyle Context: When presenting a customer churn analysis to the Marketing Team, the analyst doesn't spend 15 minutes explaining logistic regression coefficients; instead, they explain: “Customers who don't make a second purchase within 30 days are 60% more likely to churn—here are three targeted re-engagement campaigns we recommend.”

Collaboration: Active Contribution to Team & Business Goals

Data analysis is a team sport at UrbanStyle, involving product managers, fashion buyers, and software engineers.

What I look for: Willingness to share knowledge, document workflows, seek peer feedback early, and proactively align with cross-functional stakeholders.

UrbanStyle Context: A collaborative analyst documents their dbt models and SQL queries in our shared repository, seeks peer review before pushing major pipeline changes, and works closely with the inventory team to refine metric definitions (e.g., standardizing how “Return Rate” is calculated across departments).

Growth Potential: Receptivity & Self-Driven Learning

Tools and frameworks change rapidly; curiosity and adaptability are non-negotiable.

What I look for: A growth mindset. How does the candidate handle constructive feedback? How do they reflect on past technical or project failures, and what steps do they take to upskill?

UrbanStyle Context: An analyst who notices our manual reporting processes for weekly campaign performance takes the initiative to learn Airflow or automated scheduling to streamline the team's workflow.

2. Green Flags & Red Flags Summary Table

Green Flag 1 — Structured Self-Debugging & Problem Solving. Shows a clear framework for troubleshooting data discrepancies before asking for help.
Green Flag 2 — Business-First Communication. Starts presentations with key takeaways and actionable business decisions, saving technical details for the appendix.
Green Flag 3 — Proactive Knowledge Sharing & Documentation. Maintains clean repositories, clear documentation, and actively mentors peers or shares tool tips.
Red Flag 1 — “Black Box” / Isolated Execution. Works in isolation without checking in, resulting in outputs that miss the business objective or conflict with team standards.
Red Flag 2 — Defensiveness Toward Feedback. Argues against technical feedback or metric definitions rather than seeking to understand the stakeholder's perspective.

3. AI Usage Documentation (AI Hint Requirement)

To complete this assignment efficiently within the time limit, AI was utilized as follows:

Prompt Used: *“You are a Data Team Lead at an e-commerce company named UrbanStyle. Draft a general candidate evaluation framework for hiring a Data Analyst (0.5 to 1 page). Cover criteria for Independence, Communication, Collaboration, and Growth Potential, along with 3 Green Flags and 2 Red Flags. Include concrete e-commerce examples.”*